

The Weekly Digest

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THE WORLD THIS WEEK

Politics

The United Arab Emirates announced its departure from OPEC after nearly 60 years, highlighting a rift with Saudi Arabia and Gulf tensions exacerbated by the Iran war, though its immediate production capacity is limited. Diplomatic efforts between Iran and America to end their conflict stalled, with President Trump rejecting Iran's proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz before nuclear talks, maintaining blockades. Mali's defense minister was killed in coordinated jihadist and Tuareg separatist attacks, weakening the military junta and raising doubts about its Russian mercenaries. In Britain, a bill to legalize assisted dying failed in Parliament due to obstruction in the House of Lords. Mexico's president

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called for respect of national security law in joint operations after two alleged CIA agents died, while the US Justice Department charged a Mexican governor with drug conspiracy.

Business

The Federal Reserve, under outgoing chairman Jerome Powell, kept interest rates on hold due to inflation concerns from surging energy costs, with Kevin Warsh approved as his replacement. The Bank of Japan, European Central Bank, and Bank of England also held rates steady, though inflation rates in the euro zone and UK increased. Big tech companies like Alphabet, Amazon, and Microsoft reported strong earnings, but Meta signalled larger-than-expected AI spending, planning to cut 10% of its workforce. China unexpectedly blocked Meta's takeover of AI developer Manus, citing foreign investment concerns. Oil prices climbed as markets worried about the Strait of Hormuz remaining closed, boosting Q1 profits for major oil

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companies like BP and TotalEnergies, who warned against new windfall taxes.

The weekly cartoon

No significant coverage this issue.

LEADERS

Oil markets are still in La La land

Despite recent spikes in Brent crude prices above \$125 a barrel, oil markets are still underestimating the severity and duration of the supply shock caused by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Traders' optimism relies on a swift peace deal between the US and Iran, a full reopening of the strait, and immediate restoration of fuel supplies, all of which are highly uncertain. The ongoing closure of Hormuz is causing oil stocks to dwindle rapidly, with petrol and jet fuel supplies at sea already

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critically low, threatening inevitable gaps. Central banks may face a second inflationary shock, and governments, particularly in Asia and Europe, need to shift from supporting demand to managing demand destruction and potential shortages for vital services. The market's historical tendency to expect problems to resolve themselves may lead to a harsh awakening as a long-feared oil crisis approaches.

How to capitalise on London's thriving financial industry

Despite initial fears following Brexit, the City of London has retained its status as a global financial capital outside America, with financial services contributing significantly to the UK economy. The City's enduring strengths, including vast specialist networks, strategic geography, and a lack of significant European rivals, have contributed to its resilience. Recent governmental reforms, such as simplifying stock market listings and encouraging pension fund investments in risky assets,

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alongside the dropping of a bank profits levy, have improved sentiment and attracted new investment. To further capitalize on this, the government should streamline immigration for wealthy financiers with a "growth visa" and press regulators to loosen securitization rules to mobilize private capital for defense, infrastructure, and AI investments. Celebrating and expanding the City's success, rather than contemplating punitive measures, is crucial for Britain's economic growth.

How Kevin Warsh could save the Federal Reserve

Kevin Warsh, the likely next Federal Reserve chairman, faces the crucial task of safeguarding the Fed's independence against political pressure from Donald Trump, who has consistently pushed for lower interest rates despite high inflation. While Warsh has been criticized for shifting his policy stance to secure the nomination and for his vague criticisms of the central

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bank, his past advocacy for independence and credibility offers a glimmer of hope. His initial challenges will include resisting calls to loosen monetary policy amidst rising oil prices and a resilient labor market, while navigating his reform agenda, which includes shrinking the Fed's balance-sheet and reducing forward guidance. The decision by current chairman Jerome Powell and Biden appointees to remain on the board could provide Warsh with crucial allies and cover against presidential interference, allowing him to pursue reasonable reforms while maintaining the bank's integrity.

Is Samia Suluhu Hassan Africa's most disappointing president?

Tanzania's President Samia Suluhu Hassan has overseen a repressive regime, betraying initial hopes for reform after she took power in 2021 following her authoritarian predecessor. Her government's recent report whitewashing the deaths of over 500 people in post-election violence, blaming "trained agitators" and

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"outside forces" despite human rights groups implicating security forces, exemplifies this slide into autocracy. Opposition leaders and journalists are persecuted, and power is concentrated within a small circle of family members, demonstrated by the ludicrous 98% vote share she claimed in the last election. With muted international response, especially from China and a Trump-led America more focused on economic deals than human rights, Tanzania faces continued instability and deterrence for foreign investors and tourists. Hassan needs to honor her past promises, release political prisoners, allow independent investigations, and reconcile with citizens to avert further ruin.

The AI supply crunch is here

The artificial intelligence industry is facing a significant supply problem, with demand for processing power ("compute") and "tokens" (snippets of text processed by AI models) quadrupling recently. Model-makers and tech giants are rationing access to their AI tools, and

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some have even scrapped projects due to capacity constraints, indicating a choke point in AI's supply chain. Adding AI capacity is challenging due to local opposition to new data centers, delays in equipment delivery, and scarcity of specialized chips from companies like Nvidia. This scarcity means that only a few financially robust firms, primarily hyperscalers, can secure the necessary hardware, leading to high profits for chip manufacturers like Nvidia and TSMC. This supply crunch will likely slow the widespread adoption of AI technology, driving up prices and forcing users to prioritize efficiency, rather than merely using AI for every task.

The UAE doubles down on Israel and America

The United Arab Emirates' decision to leave OPEC after years of chafing against production quotas signals its firm alignment with America and Israel, intensifying its rivalry with Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states. The

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UAE aims to increase its oil production to 5m barrels a day by 2027, prioritizing volume over high prices, which clashes with OPEC's goals. While OPEC's immediate relevance might be limited during the ongoing war, the UAE's departure weakens the cartel in the long term, leaving Saudi Arabia with most of the remaining spare capacity. The move is seen as a strategic bid to strengthen security ties with America and Israel, especially after suffering Iranian missile attacks, and to further diversify its economy through partnerships in technology and investment. This unilateral decision, made amid regional instability, carries risks for the UAE, especially if Iran emerges more powerful or Gulf relations deteriorate further.

Time to edit some biological metaphors

The article criticizes the pervasive and often misleading use of DNA as a metaphor for immutable traits, particularly in non-biological contexts, arguing that it oversimplifies complex human characteristics and can

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lead to dangerous essentialist views. It welcomes the growing interest in epigenomic medicine, which offers a more nuanced understanding of genetics by focusing on "epigenomic tags" that regulate gene expression without altering the underlying DNA sequence. These tags can be influenced by environment and lifestyle, and potentially inherited, with significant impacts on health, as seen in genetically identical mice with different epigenomic markings. Biotech companies are developing epigenetic editing techniques to treat metabolic disorders, chronic viral conditions, and even age-related debilities by modifying these tags. While its immediate benefit is medical, this field could help shift societal understanding away from rigid biological determinism, though the human tendency to oversimplify complexities remains a challenge.

LETTERS

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AI and the associated risks are challenging policymakers to develop regulations quickly

Letters discuss the urgent need for international AI regulation, with some experts warning of a 5-10% chance of human extinction or catastrophe due to superintelligent AI and recursive self-improvement. Concerns are raised about Anthropic dropping its safety pledge and AI firms rapidly developing powerful systems without adequate safeguards. Investors are also highlighted as accountable, as their capital shapes which AI applications are prioritized, potentially integrating Big Tech with military tech without sufficient due diligence or consideration for international law. The comparison to the Manhattan Project suggests government control is needed for AI's destructive potential, hoping for survival as in the nuclear age. Other letters defended Thomas Malthus, critiqued British universities' management structures, and offered tips for reducing buffet food waste.

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BY INVITATION

Stop big tech from making users behave in ways they don't want to

Marie Potel-Saville argues that Big Tech companies employ "predatory design" and "addiction engineering" to manipulate user behavior, exemplified by Meta's internal documents targeting tweens to maximize "total teen time spent" on Instagram. She cites Amazon's "misdirection" tactics to trap users in Prime subscriptions and "dark patterns" that exploit cognitive biases. These techniques go beyond traditional competition law concerns by directly targeting the brain's reward system through features like infinite scroll and unpredictable algorithmic feeds, manufacturing compulsion rather than facilitating choice. Potel-Saville proposes that the burden of proof should shift to platforms, requiring them to demonstrate that engagement mechanics are not predatory by design before deployment, a standard

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applied to drugs and medical devices. This systemic response is necessary to restore genuine market functionality and consumer autonomy.

BRIEFING

The crisis in oil markets will get bigger before it goes away

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz, through which nearly a fifth of the world's oil usually flows, has created the biggest oil supply shock in history, yet oil prices remain relatively muted. This market composure belies a severe looming reckoning, as approximately 12.3m barrels per day of oil have been removed from global supply. Spare production capacity is largely behind the blockade or cannot ramp up quickly enough, leaving stock drawdowns and demand curtailment as the primary adjustment mechanisms. Despite initial demand

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destruction in the Middle East and Asia, global stocks are being drained at an unsustainable rate of 8m b/d, threatening widespread shortages within weeks. The effects will ripple globally, with East Africa already facing queues, Asia slashing refinery output, and Europe reliant on dwindling imports, while America faces rising pump prices as summer driving season approaches.

UNITED STATES

Donald Trump is crushing America's farmers?yet they back him

American farmers are facing severe financial strain due to Donald Trump's trade war and the ongoing conflict in Iran, yet they largely continue to support him. Trump's tariffs have increased the cost of machinery and prompted retaliatory measures from countries like China, severely impacting soybean and cotton exports. The Iran

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war further compounds these issues by driving up diesel fuel prices and fertilizer costs, the latter being critical and bottlenecked by the Strait of Hormuz closure. Despite record farm bankruptcies and widespread economic hardship spreading to rural businesses, many farmers express trust in the administration, seeking government relief and subsidies. This loyalty persists even as their livelihoods are directly harmed by the foreign policies they nonetheless seem to endorse.

A radical idea for governing California

Matt Mahan, the 43-year-old mayor of San Jose and a candidate for California governor, is pitching himself as a pragmatic problem-solver committed to effective governance, rather than ideologically driven politics. Mahan's campaign focuses on addressing pressing issues like housing shortages and homelessness, drawing on his record in San Jose, where he's tried to reduce housing fees and increased the proportion of homeless people in shelters. His approach, popular among wonkier

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Democrats, aims to demonstrate that the party can govern effectively, standing up to both his allies and the president. Despite being a long shot in a crowded race, his focus on tangible results, such as using AI for traffic coordination, and his appeal to some tech moguls, aims to resonate with voters frustrated by California's persistent challenges.

Voters say they want young candidates. In practice, they do not

Despite survey data indicating that Americans desire a new generation of leaders, voters often prioritize experience over youth in practice, as illustrated by the Massachusetts Democratic Senate primary. Incumbent Ed Markey, 86, is comfortably leading his 47-year-old challenger, Seth Moulton, who has made age a central campaign theme. Older incumbents benefit from deeper pockets and establishment support, making them formidable opponents. While young Democrats are more inclined to favor youth, roughly half of them either

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express no preference or prefer experience. This suggests that voters are not necessarily ageist, but rather weigh age against other factors, such as a candidate's perceived ability to perform the job, which Markey's voters still attribute to him.

A mogul alleges he has been swindled by a Trump-affiliated crypto project

Justin Sun, a crypto billionaire, has filed a federal lawsuit alleging he was swindled out of \$276m by World Liberty Financial (WLFI), a crypto project affiliated with the Trump family. Sun claims his investment in WLFI tokens, made shortly after his own fraud case with the SEC was settled for a significantly reduced fine, was frozen when he refused to invest more in a related stablecoin. The lawsuit alleges WLFI retaliated by preventing him from selling his tokens and stripping his voting rights, actions vehemently denied by WLFI CEO Zach Witkoff. This scandal, which also implicated Witkoff in a past cocaine arrest, adds to the negative

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sentiment around crypto and tangentially involves the Trump family, though it may do little damage to either's reputation given already low public trust.

The government's lawsuit against the Southern Poverty Law Center is bonkers

The Department of Justice has indicted the Southern Poverty Law Center (SPLC), a progressive non-profit, on wire-fraud charges, alleging it defrauded donors by secretly paying informants within far-right groups. This lawsuit, applauded by Donald Trump, is seen as politically motivated and legally flimsy, as using informants is a standard, lawful intelligence-gathering tactic, even for government agencies. The government's decision to expose details about these informants in a public docket is particularly reckless, potentially endangering their lives in violent extremist circles. This callousness sends a dangerous message to non-profits and informants, risking the blunting of effective tools for gathering intelligence on domestic threats in pursuit of a

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presidential vendetta. The SPLC, while having faced criticism for labeling mainstream conservative groups as extremists, is now a target in a sloppiest attack yet on the president's foes.

THE AMERICAS

A tour of Brazil's wildly polarised politics

Brazil, one of the world's most unequal and racially mixed countries, is experiencing deep political polarization, with the upcoming election set to be another divisive contest between Lula and Flávio Bolsonaro. Despite geographical and social disparities, voters across the political spectrum share common grievances, particularly a strong disdain for political corruption and a belief that the powerful Supreme Court needs reforms. The Lula-supporting north-east benefits from extensive welfare programs like Bolsa Família,

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which has significantly reduced poverty, while the Bolsonaro-aligned south-east resents these handouts, viewing them as tax burdens that fuel corruption. High living costs and soaring interest rates are also common complaints, indicating that while political figures clash, a demand for a middle-of-the-road candidate and genuine solutions to shared economic problems exists.

The Caribbean island that calls Colombia a coloniser

San Andrés, a popular Colombian tourist island, faces mounting problems like crime, corruption, and environmental degradation, leading a growing number of Afro-Caribbean Raizal residents to demand independence from Colombia. Raizals accuse the mainland Colombians of destroying their environment, appropriating land, and eroding their identity, feeling "subjugated" and preferring ties to England, their "mother country." Despite constitutional recognition of their ethnic rights since 1991 and recent gestures from

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Colombia's president, Raizals seek full autonomy, including electing their own leaders. However, secession seems unlikely as most of the island's population is not Raizal, and Colombia remains committed to its sovereignty while attempting to address decolonization issues within its own borders.

ASIA

Ageing workers in East Asia are essential. More are needed

Japan and South Korea, two of the world's fastest-aging countries, are increasingly relying on older workers, with nearly 40% of South Koreans and over 25% of Japanese aged 65+ remaining employed. Many work out of necessity due to inadequate pension systems, but others seek social engagement and health benefits. Companies are adapting by consulting on later-career options and

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adjusting roles, yet older workers often face high barriers like seniority-based wage systems and rampant age discrimination, leading many to temporary or menial jobs. Governments are promoting longer employment through initiatives like job centers and part-time schemes, recognizing the dual benefits of compensating for shrinking youth populations and reducing healthcare costs. However, maximizing the potential of this demographic requires ambitious redesigns of social systems and hiring practices, encouraging a mindset of "starting over from scratch" for later-stage careers.

Indonesia suggests charging a toll to transit the Malacca Strait

Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto and his finance minister have suggested charging a toll for transit through the Strait of Malacca, drawing parallels to Iran's actions in the Strait of Hormuz. Indonesia occupies a highly strategic position, with its straits handling a significant portion of East Asia's energy needs and trade,

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making it a critical chokepoint for global shipping. While similar proposals in the past were rejected by Singapore, which fears disruption to its busy port, Iran's recent actions have reignited these concerns. Indonesian officials, however, have since clarified that they will respect international law, particularly UNCLOS, which guarantees innocent passage through its straits in exchange for recognition of its archipelagic claims. Despite this, the prominent floating of the idea suggests it may resurface in future discussions, especially given global reliance on international law is waning.

Is Vietnam's latest railway ambition worthwhile?

Vietnam's leaders have revived plans for a 1,540km high-speed railway connecting Ho Chi Minh City to Hanoi, estimated to cost \$70bn—14% of the country's current GDP—making it Vietnam's largest infrastructure project. The ambitious project, previously blocked by the National Assembly in 2009, faces significant funding

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challenges, with no eligible bidders emerging after a major Vietnamese conglomerate withdrew its offer. Hanoi is wary of Chinese influence, having observed Indonesia's financial strain from a Chinese-backed high-speed rail. While the railway could boost economic growth and development, critics suggest scaling down the project, starting with the most profitable southern leg, would be a more prudent approach.

Climate change is forcing Vanuatu to confront an unthinkable future

The South Pacific archipelago of Vanuatu is grappling with the severe, immediate impacts of climate change, with rising sea levels causing significant coastal erosion, saltwater intrusion, and the loss of land. Locals on islands like Nguna report the shoreline receding by 20 meters in recent decades, with failed coastal defenses and washed-away cemeteries. Vanuatu is advocating for a UN resolution on climate change, seeking financial help and accountability for inaction, but action may

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come too late for much of the country. The nation faces frequent natural disasters, and its limited resources make dealing with this crisis exceptionally difficult. Relocating affected populations is a proposed solution, but it is complicated by Vanuatu's intricate traditional land-ownership systems and potential tensions between tribal groups.

Making India's numbers count again

India is making strides in restoring the credibility of its national statistics, which had suffered from neglect and political interference, reaching a nadir in the 2010s. The government's own think-tank has acknowledged that policy has been based on untrusted numbers, prompting the appointment of Saurabh Garg to lead reforms at the statistics ministry. Garg has introduced a data release calendar, cleared backlogs, and organized workshops, earning praise from experts for his non-ideological approach. His focus now includes producing more granular economic data at the district level and preparing

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statistical infrastructure for AI. However, India's broader administrative capacity remains severely constrained by a small civil service, which relies heavily on individual capabilities rather than established processes, raising concerns about the long-term sustainability of these improvements once key individuals like Garg move on.

CHINA

Cai Qi may be China's second-most powerful man

Cai Qi, a long-time associate of Xi Jinping, has emerged as potentially the second-most powerful figure in China, holding the unprecedented dual roles of head of the party's powerful General Office and head of the Central Secretariat. In these capacities, he controls Xi's schedule, information flow, personal security, and oversees the day-to-day operations of the party apparatus. His

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extensive responsibilities, including a role on the National Security Commission, give him access to sensitive party and security information, making him a person of significant interest to foreign governments. Despite technically ranking fifth in the Politburo Standing Committee, his functional influence appears to surpass that of Premier Li Qiang, with some analysts suggesting he is a potential successor should anything happen to Xi. Cai's rapid ascent from relative obscurity and his lack of an independent power base mean his authority is entirely derived from Xi, making him a loyal enforcer valued for his hard-nosed administration during his tenure as Beijing party chief.

Hong Kong is a good place to find stolen or looted Chinese artefacts

Hong Kong has become a significant gateway for the illicit trade of Chinese antiquities, despite China's strict export controls and international conventions against smuggling. Unlike mainland China, Hong Kong is not

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party to these conventions and has lax laws protecting archaeological objects, making it a free port ideal for transiting stolen wares. The legal principle of "market overt" further exacerbates the issue, allowing buyers to gain "good title" to stolen items if purchased in good faith from a shop, effectively legitimizing illicit goods. This situation allows looted artefacts, including "grade-one national treasures" like Sanxingdui masks, to be sold with little legal recourse for repatriation. This ongoing illicit trade results in a huge loss of historical knowledge, particularly from ancient cultures with few intact sites remaining.

China is seeking self-sufficiency in police dogs

China is actively promoting self-sufficiency in police dogs, celebrating its home-grown "Kunming" breed as a strategically important alternative to foreign imports. Developed from German Shepherds and local wolf-dog hybrids, nearly 1,000 Kunming pups are born annually,

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lauded for their intelligence, fierceness, and adaptability to diverse conditions, as well as a "sharper nose." The public security ministry has mandated police forces replace foreign dogs with Kunmings, reinforcing national pride and reducing reliance on foreign sources. State media highlights their capabilities in dramatic videos and their patriotic deployment in key locations, with China even providing them as gifts to neighboring countries to boost its brand. This effort reflects a broader push for self-reliance in critical sectors and a preference for a more intimidating image than traditional Chinese toy breeds.

Xi Jinping wants China to read more?as long as it?s the right books

Xi Jinping is leading a new campaign to encourage deeper reading in China, aiming to shift people away from phone screens and towards physical books and classics. While China boasts near-universal literacy, adult physical book consumption is low, a common

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problem globally. The campaign's unique Chinese twist reflects Xi's preoccupations with techno-nationalism, believing deep reading fosters innovation and cultural powerhouse status by 2035, and reverence for Chinese tradition. New regulations focus on creating reading spaces and supporting bookshops, but concrete measures are limited. However, this initiative is highly selective about what is read: books critical of the party or unapproved genres like danmei fiction are censored or blocked, pushing original Chinese literature online or abroad. The party desires more reading but not necessarily wide, intellectually risky, or diverse engagement, ultimately limiting the campaign's true value.

MIDDLE EAST & AFRICA

The UAE's departure from OPEC may not break the cartel

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The United Arab Emirates (UAE) announced its departure from OPEC, OPEC's third-largest exporter, highlighting severe tensions with Saudi Arabia, the bloc's de facto leader. While OPEC has survived previous departures, the UAE's move deepens the rivalry between the two major Gulf powers, who disagree on production quotas and strategy. The UAE aims to increase its oil production to 5m barrels a day by 2027, prioritizing volume over high prices, which clashes with OPEC's objectives. In the short term, its exports are constrained by Iran's blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, but the decision is a strategic play to align closer with America and Israel for security and economic diversification. While its exit weakens the cartel over time, it's not immediately fatal, but further souring relations with Saudi Arabia may be a price the UAE is willing to pay for deeper ties with the US.

A political merger kicks off Israel's election season

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Israel's election season has begun with former prime ministers Naftali Bennett and Yair Lapid merging their parties under Bennett's leadership to form a new bloc named "Together," aiming to unseat Binyamin Netanyahu. Despite Netanyahu's government facing multiple costly wars, constitutional turmoil, and corruption allegations, he retains an advantage due to the opposition's deep divisions and disparate ideologies. The Bennett-Lapid partnership, which previously briefly kept Netanyahu out of office, seeks to reduce fragmentation in the anti-Netanyahu camp, drawing parallels to Hungary's united opposition. However, the new party ruled out including Arab parties, and their campaign will focus on Netanyahu's failures in handling the October 2023 Hamas attacks and the ultra-Orthodox exemption from military service, rather than broader issues like the Palestinian territories.

The lack of progress in Gaza suits those in power

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A grim limbo has settled over Gaza, benefiting various powerful actors while leaving Gazans in misery, despite a ceasefire and a 20-point relief plan announced by Donald Trump. Israel continues to extend its control, restricting aid and items for reconstruction, seemingly hoping conditions become intolerable enough for inhabitants to leave. Hamas clings to its shrinking authority, extracting revenue from inflated prices to pay salaries, and its leaders, emboldened by Iran's resilience, set demanding conditions for disarmament. Mahmoud Abbas, the Palestinian Authority president, fears fragmentation and shows little interest in administering Gaza separately. The National Committee for the Administration of Gaza (NCAG), meant to take over, remains sidelined in Cairo, unable to act.

Hizbullah's air of invincibility is gone

Hizbullah, the Iran-backed militia in Lebanon, claims survival after the recent conflicts, but its aura of invincibility has been shattered due to significant losses

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and ongoing Israeli attacks. Despite its assertion as both a political party and an armed "resistance" group, Lebanon's government leaders are increasingly challenging its autonomy. President Joseph Aoun and Prime Minister Nawaf Salam are pursuing direct talks with Israel without Hizbullah's approval, a move the militia cannot stop. While Hizbullah officially denies any truce and maintains its right to fire missiles, its capacity to rearm could be compromised if Iran's proxies are part of a deal with America.

Could China help make Africa a factory for the world?

Chinese foreign direct investment in African manufacturing surged to \$12.3bn in 2025, suggesting a shifting relationship where Chinese firms are increasingly building factories across the continent, particularly in Kenya. While the dream of Africa becoming the "factory of the world" hasn't fully materialized, Chinese manufacturers are drawn by

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Africa's growing population and improving economic prospects, but primarily by challenges at home like slowing economic growth and fierce price wars. These Chinese-owned factories often focus on serving local and regional African markets, which may not align with the export-led growth model typically associated with development, but they do provide jobs and training. Concerns exist about Chinese firms displacing indigenous manufacturing and Africa's widening trade deficit with China, but some argue they fill gaps in domestic capabilities and could grow into global exporters.

African finance goes global

African fintech companies are rapidly expanding to ease cross-border payments for businesses and the continent's growing diaspora, aiming to capture a significant share of the \$47bn in annual revenue McKinsey projects for African fintechs by 2028. Traditional banking systems in Africa are slow and expensive, necessitating costly

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currency conversions and paperwork, creating an opportunity for fintech alternatives. Companies like Wave and Flutterwave operate across multiple countries, bypassing banks, while others use stablecoins or partner with mobile network operators to facilitate instant, cheaper transfers. While these innovations have reduced average transaction costs from 8% to under 6% since 2015, challenges such as poor internet penetration and restrictive government regulations continue to hinder seamless, continent-wide financial integration.

EUROPE

How to protect France from an Orban-style takeover

Emmanuel Macron is taking steps to "autocrat-proof" France's institutions against a potential populist-right victory in next year's presidential election, by appointing

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allies to key positions in the military, state auditor, and Constitutional Council. Leaders of the National Rally (RN), Marine Le Pen and Jordan Bardella, who currently top polls, accuse Macron of trying to "lock down" institutions, highlighting concerns about state capture in France's highly centralized system. Three main worries include the potential misuse of the Fifth Republic's constitution, particularly Articles 16 (emergency powers) and 11 (referendums for constitutional changes); judicial independence, as RN leaders have criticized court rulings as "political decisions"; and the media, with RN favoring privatization of public broadcasting and embracing friendly private outlets. Despite the RN denying anti-democratic intent and France's robust institutions, the sobering lessons from Hungary and America suggest that democratic backsliding remains a real threat, especially if norms fail.

The oligarch who picked Moldova clean goes to prison

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Vlad Plahotniuc, a Moldovan oligarch known as "Mr P," was sentenced to 19 years in jail and fined \$60m for his role in stealing \$1bn from the country's banks between 2013 and 2015. This conviction marks a significant step towards judicial reform in Moldova, a key demand for its aspirations to join the European Union. Plahotniuc, who controlled nearly every aspect of the country's government and economy during his tenure, fled in 2019 and was arrested in Greece last year with 17 forged passports. The case demonstrates that despite strong resistance to cleaning up the judiciary, reforms are beginning to work, as the fear he once commanded over public and legal institutions has diminished.

The fashion influencer speaking truth to Putin

Victoria Bonya, a Russian fashion influencer, unexpectedly triggered a political uproar with a viral Instagram video criticizing Vladimir Putin and airing popular grievances about inadequate government

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responses to disasters and internet restrictions. Her appeal, framed as a petition to a "good tsar," resonated deeply with a disengaged majority of Russians, accumulating 10m views and prompting a mixed, though ultimately conciliatory, response from the Kremlin. This incident revealed growing popular discontent beyond the anti-war minority, fueled by mounting economic costs of the Ukraine war, rising casualties, and the absence of an end in sight. The Kremlin's efforts to control the digital ecosystem through surveillance and bans are increasingly seen as intrusions into personal lives, highlighting the limits of its political technology strategy.

Europe's unpopular leaders are paralysing the EU

Europe's leaders are currently facing unprecedented levels of unpopularity, with Emmanuel Macron of France and Friedrich Merz of Germany registering particularly low approval ratings. This "coalition of the

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weakened" is paralyzing the European Union, as unpopular national leaders lack the political capital to make the crucial compromises and trade-offs needed for ambitious EU-level reforms. This comes at a critical time when Europe faces daunting collective challenges, including a reheated energy crisis, the war in Ukraine, a flabby economy, and stalled enlargement. Instead of pursuing grand bargains, leaders are resorting to "bashing the EU" as a distraction, risking a "doom loop" where weakened Brussels becomes an easier target for criticism, further undermining its effectiveness and the collective action required to address shared problems.

BRITAIN

Has the City of London finally got its mojo back?

Despite dire predictions following Brexit, the City of

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London's financial-services sector has not only recovered but is thriving, with employment numbers holding steady and economic output increasing by 20% in real terms since 2017. The Square Mile is once again bustling, challenging New York's position in global financial competitiveness indices, driven by improving sentiment among financiers. London remains a global leader in cross-border finance, particularly in currency trading, insurance, and derivatives, benefiting from its historical networks and strategic time zone. However, its role as a capital for domestic growth is more mixed, with a decline in global share across several finance areas linked to the local economy, and a struggle to attract international stock market listings. Recent policy shifts from the Treasury, encouraging pension fund investment in risky assets, and simplified listing rules are praised for making the City more attractive.

**Why business at London's
specialty-insurance hub has surged**

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Lloyd's of London, a world-renowned specialty-insurance marketplace, has seen a boom in business, with contract values doubling in real terms since 2015 and a growing share in global marine, energy, and property insurance markets. Its strength lies in the concentration of specialists and a unique structure that fosters innovation, covering complex risks from cars to cyber and energy infrastructure. The market has been exceptionally profitable in recent years due to rising prices after a series of disasters and fewer catastrophes since 2022, leading to pre-tax profits of £10.6bn in 2025. While competition is increasing and prices are starting to cool, Lloyd's enduring reputation for covering devastating claims, from the Titanic to recent wars, ensures its continued leadership in specialist insurance.

The City of London is becoming a seven-day-a-week destination

The City of London, historically a weekday-only financial district, is transforming into a vibrant

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seven-day-a-week destination, with weekend footfall rising by 8% last year. This shift is a deliberate strategy by the City of London Corporation, prompted by Brexit and the covid-19 pandemic, to "reimagine" the Square Mile. The area now boasts a thriving nightlife, with numerous restaurants, pubs, bars, hotels, and nightclubs. Tourism plays a significant role, with hotel-room revenues increasing faster than in other parts of London, and excellent transport links facilitate weekend access.

The question of Scottish independence is alive but not kicking

The upcoming Scottish parliamentary elections on May 7th show voter fatigue, with the ruling Scottish National Party (SNP) less popular but likely to remain in power. The independence question, a key SNP platform, is split among Scots and remains a distant prospect due to the UK government's refusal to grant another referendum. Voters are prioritizing immediate issues like the economy and the NHS over constitutional change, with

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independence ranking sixth in importance. While Brexit boosted independence support, and Westminster's unpopularity could eventually grow support, a pragmatic path of gradual devolution is not being championed by any party. The political landscape is fragmented, with Reform UK expected to become the second-largest party in Scotland, reflecting a desire for tangible change rather than constitutional upheaval.

The battle between Scotland's two national languages

Scotland is home to two national languages, Scottish Gaelic and Scots, but government funding and patriotic fervor favor Gaelic, leading to its resurgence while Scots declines. Gaelic, rooted in Old Irish, was once repressed but now has nearly 70,000 speakers, a 20% increase since 2011, boosted by significant government investment. In contrast, Scots, a Germanic language related to English, is spoken by 1.5 million people but is quietly declining, losing nearly 30,000 speakers between

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2011 and 2022. Due to its resemblance to English, Scots struggles to inspire the same patriotic sentiment as Gaelic, receiving only 3% of the funding allocated to Gaelic initiatives. This reflects a broader impulse to emphasize what distinguishes Scotland from its southern neighbor, rather than what they share.

If Labour loses Wales on May 7th, it will snap a world record

The Labour Party faces the potential end of its 104-year dominance in Wales in the May 7th Senedd elections, a streak that would mark a world record for political party hegemony in a democracy. Polls suggest Plaid Cymru, a nationalist party, is set to win, with Reform UK potentially coming second. This outcome would be a significant blow to Labour, which views Wales as central to its identity, and would signal a cultural shift for the nation. Historically, Labour's hold in areas like the Ebbw Fach valley was built on the coal industry and strong community ties, leading to unwavering support despite

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political changes. However, fragmentation, discontent with public services, and the rise of other parties mean this long-standing communal voting culture is now fading.

Zack Polanski is Britain's first digital-native party leader

Zack Polanski, leader of Britain's Green Party, exemplifies a "digital-native" politician, actively engaging with supporters on microblogging sites like Bluesky, Instagram, and TikTok. An analysis of his 35,000 Bluesky "likes" reveals constant interaction with supportive posts celebrating the Green Party and denouncing Labour and Israel's government, often liking multiple posts per hour throughout the day. However, his online activity also shows a thin-skinned and hostile side towards journalists, with numerous liked posts criticizing their character and arguments. While his prolific digital presence energizes activists and contributes to the party's rising polls, it also exposes him to the "toxic cesspit" of

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social media, leading to instances where he has had to remove problematic likes.

Bagehot

The Jaecoo 7, a cut-price Chinese SUV resembling a Range Rover, has become Britain's bestselling car, dubbed the "Temu Range Rover," reflecting British consumers' preference for value over brand loyalty or patriotism. Despite initial expert criticism, its affordability (£29,000) and generous financing deals, like 0% APR, resonate with a nation experiencing a cost-of-living crisis. Chinese cars now account for 15% of new sales in Britain, the highest in major European markets, as British drivers prioritize cheap options. Politicians are wary of imposing tariffs on Chinese cars, understanding that intervening between Britons and affordable vehicles is politically perilous. This trend highlights a broader cultural inclination in Britain to value saving money, even among the well-to-do, and suggests that a "classless car" that is "looked down on by

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some, while enjoyed by many more" has found a lucrative niche.

INTERNATIONAL

Countries are rushing to build ports in a contest to secure maritime trade routes

A global rush to build port infrastructure is underway, driven by anxiety over China's tightening grip on maritime supply chains and recent disruptions to global trade routes. China has invested over \$80bn in 129 ports outside its borders, many near strategic chokepoints, allowing Chinese firms to prioritize their cargo and vessels. This dominance has spurred Western governments and shipping companies to beef up their own networks, with non-Chinese firms making \$140bn in acquisitions since 2021. The US, in particular, is taking an antagonistic approach, backing alternative port

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developments and challenging Chinese control in strategic locations like the Panama Canal. This intense competition will lead to significant inefficiencies, disappointing returns for some investors, and political pressure for shippers to use specific, commercially illogical routes, potentially resulting in higher fixed costs and consumer prices despite increased capacity.

To fight Russia, Europe needs Ukraine

European leaders, despite voicing fears of Russian aggression, exhibit ambivalence towards Ukraine's full EU membership, pushing for associate forms rather than the accelerated timeline Ukraine seeks. While concerns exist regarding Ukraine's corruption, fragility, and the impact on EU farm subsidies, a counter-argument emphasizes that Europe crucially needs Ukraine's large, battle-hardened military and advanced drone technologies for its own defense. With NATO membership for Ukraine effectively "dead," EU accession remains the primary path for Ukraine to

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anchor itself in the democratic world. Some leaders are cautiously endorsing provisional membership, potentially extending Article 42.7 mutual-defense clauses, recognizing that spurning Ukraine could lead to future instability or closer ties with Russia. This complex stance highlights a fundamental dilemma: Europe's security is intertwined with Ukraine, but leaders struggle to reconcile this with short-term political and economic concerns, raising questions about Europe's readiness to fight.

BUSINESS

The AI rush is hitting a bottleneck

The booming demand for artificial intelligence, particularly "tokens" processed by AI models, is encountering a significant bottleneck as hardware manufacturers fail to keep pace with investment. AI labs

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like Anthropic and OpenAI are rationing access, experiencing outages, and shutting down less critical tools to manage scarce computing power. While hyperscalers are investing heavily in data centers, their hardware suppliers, including chipmakers like TSMC and memory producers, are not increasing their capital expenditure at the same rate. This capacity squeeze is exacerbated by growing political opposition to data center construction and existing shortages of critical components like Nvidia GPUs and high-bandwidth memory. The imbalance between rapidly advancing software and slow-to-expand supply chains suggests that the "tokenmaxxing" craze will likely be cut short, leading to sustained shortages for the next several years.

Why DeepSeek's sequel failed to impress

DeepSeek, a Chinese AI startup that previously stunned the world with its cost-effective models, has released its new v4 model to a lukewarm reception, indicating stiffening competition and state interference. While

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DeepSeek v4 offers performance comparable to leading American models from months ago and is significantly cheaper for customers, its underlying build cost is likely much higher than its predecessor, as details on training costs were omitted. China's AI scene is increasingly crowded with rivals like Alibaba and ByteDance, which are focusing on building "super apps" powered by AI rather than just model development. DeepSeek has also faced state pressure to use Huawei chips, though it ultimately relied on Nvidia's, and the government recently blocked Meta's acquisition of another Chinese AI firm, highlighting ongoing meddling.

Elon Musk and Sam Altman bring their rivalry to court

The courtroom drama of Elon Musk v Sam Altman et al, a trial with profound implications for OpenAI, has begun with a display of the two billionaires' mutual animosity. Musk alleges that Altman and Greg Brockman "stole a charity" by creating a for-profit arm for OpenAI, which

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he helped fund as a non-profit aimed at safe AI for humanity, and that they enriched themselves with Microsoft's support. OpenAI and Microsoft counter that no promise to remain a charity existed, attributing Musk's lawsuit to "sour grapes" after he founded his own AI lab, XAI. The trial is expected to reveal more salacious details and will determine whether OpenAI's restructuring is valid, potentially hurting the company if Musk wins, though betting markets deem this unlikely.

Coca-Cola is trouncing Pepsi. Can the underdog turn things around?

Coca-Cola has significantly outpaced Pepsi in market value appreciation recently, with Pepsi facing challenges from high post-pandemic price increases, shifting consumer health consciousness, and the rise of weight-loss drugs. Pepsi, which earns over half its revenue from packaged food and bottles its own drinks, has seen its market value slump compared to Coca-Cola's rise. An activist investor, Elliott

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Management, spurred Pepsi to cut costs, trim its product range, focus on core soda marketing, and consider outsourcing bottling. These strategic shifts, including lowering prices and acquiring a prebiotic soda brand, are showing early positive results, with Pepsi reporting stronger operating profit growth than Coca-Cola in the first quarter of 2026.

How a mega-deal will transform the lift industry

Finland's Kone and Germany's TKE are merging in a ?29.4bn deal that will create the world's largest liftmaker, with a global market share of 28%, towering over rivals like Otis and Schindler. The acquisition, expected to yield ?700m in annual cost savings, combines complementary strengths, with Kone strong in China and TKE in America, expanding their service networks. This merger is strategically important as servicing and modernization represent the most lucrative revenue streams in the \$110bn lift industry, far outpacing

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new lift sales. With 10m lifts over 15 years old in 2024 expected to rise to 16m by 2030, the combined entity is well-positioned to capitalize on the growing modernization market.

Swashbuckling oil-services firms are preparing for a boom

Oil-services firms, including industry leaders Baker Hughes, Halliburton, and SLB, are bracing for a future boom despite short-term pain from the Iran war, which has reduced Middle East revenues. The prospective boom is driven by two main factors: an estimated \$50bn in post-war reconstruction of oil-and-gas infrastructure in the Middle East and a potential loosening of purse-strings by oil majors. After years of underinvestment due to decarbonization worries, the oil shock may push majors to invest in new reserves to meet demand, diversifying away from the Gulf to regions like Africa, South America, and American shale. This shift towards energy security for oil-importing nations is

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expected to drive upstream spending for years, benefiting the oil-services industry.

AI and the danger of cognitive surrender

The article explores the potential cognitive effects of AI, drawing parallels with calculators and GPS systems which, while useful for "cognitive offloading," can also diminish users' ability to think independently. It introduces "cognitive surrender," a concept describing how AI's broad capabilities and confident persona can lead to wholesale capitulation of human thought. Research shows that while AI can boost performance with accurate answers, users perform worse than control groups when AI provides incorrect information, indicating a cessation of independent thinking. Managers are advised to encourage "cognitive resistance" by hiring critical thinkers and implementing incentives and feedback mechanisms to prompt users to override AI, potentially even instituting AI-free periods to prevent over-reliance and foster deeper engagement.

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SpaceX, OpenAI and Anthropic are already public companies

SpaceX, OpenAI, and Anthropic, though not yet formally public, already influence public markets through their enormous valuations and the numerous investment vehicles tied to their success. SpaceX's anticipated \$2trn IPO is already bending public markets, with Nasdaq changing rules to attract it, and existing listed companies like Tesla and Alphabet serving as proxies for its private stock. Similarly, the fortunes of OpenAI and Anthropic ripple through public markets, affecting share prices of investors like SoftBank and Zoom. This phenomenon highlights a significant experiment in American capitalism, where value is highly concentrated among a few enormous firms, while diverse, often speculative, investment products proliferate, allowing investors to wager on these select entities before their official market debut.

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FINANCE & ECONOMICS

Will Kevin Warsh Trumpify the Federal Reserve?

Kevin Warsh, the incoming Fed chair, is expected to pursue a modest "regime change" at the Federal Reserve, despite fears that he would reshape it in a "Trumpier" mould. His ideas, such as trimming the balance-sheet and skepticism of "forward guidance," are either marginal, outdated, or require the consensus of the Board of Governors. While he abandoned his hawkish stance to secure the nomination and avoided condemning Trump's election claims, he has distanced himself from purging regional Fed presidents. The decision of outgoing chair Jerome Powell and Biden appointees to remain on the board further constrains Warsh, making radical transformations unlikely. However, his tendency to criticize the institution he's about to lead could exacerbate the politicization of America's central bank.

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How Kalshi can help the Federal Reserve

Americans are increasingly using prediction markets like Kalshi and Polymarket to bet on economic conditions, attracting the attention of the Federal Reserve. A recent Fed paper suggests that Kalshi could be a valuable complement to traditional data sources, as its predictions for interest rates often outperform conventional instruments like futures. Prediction markets also offer real-time, constantly updated forecasts for indicators like GDP growth and unemployment, which are often as accurate as professional consensus forecasts, and in some cases, superior. Despite limitations such as thin trading volumes and potential correlation with professional forecasts, the incoming Fed chair, Kevin Warsh, is a known advocate for real-time economic indicators.

San Francisco, AI capital of the world, is an economic laggard

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Despite being the global epicenter of the artificial intelligence boom, San Francisco is experiencing a surprisingly weak economy, struggling with a soft housing market and declining employment in non-AI tech sectors. While luxury housing prices are rising in exclusive districts, this is attributed to broader economic trends and a diverse set of plutocrats, not solely AI moguls. In contrast, real housing prices in many areas, like SoMa, are significantly down, reflecting widespread office vacancies and a shrinking labor force. The "deep state" of inspectors and non-profits continues to impose high costs, while many moderate-income residents are leaving the city. The AI revolution's benefits are not yet broadly felt, and a potential new wealth tax on billionaires could accelerate departures, exacerbating the city's persistent budgetary deficits.

A global fight over banking rules is just getting started

A global battle over banking regulations is intensifying,

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threatening the international cooperation that established protective capital buffers after the 2008 financial crisis. American regulators have been particularly aggressive, reducing capital charges for big banks and dropping the "output floor" concept from Basel III rules, which limits banks' reliance on self-assessments of risk. This unilateral deregulation worries European lenders, who fear a competitive disadvantage from stricter rules and are now also easing their own capital requirements or delaying implementation of Basel rules. While some individual adjustments to rules may be justified, the overall trend towards lower capital requirements is dangerous, as finance is prone to catastrophic global failures, and unilateral actions inevitably provoke retaliatory deregulation.

India's weak currency reflects deeper problems than the Iran war

India's weak rupee, which lost about a tenth of its value against the dollar in the fiscal year to March, reflects

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deeper structural problems than just the Iran war, leading to Britain regaining its spot as the world's fifth-largest economy. The currency's real effective exchange rate is collapsing, largely due to India's struggle to attract foreign capital, with significant outflows from both debt and equity portfolios since 2025. Foreign direct investment has also seen net outflows, as investors are deterred by high valuations, a lack of AI firms, and India's shabby infrastructure and bureaucracy. While the Iran war exacerbates the situation by increasing energy import costs, the Reserve Bank of India's attempts to stabilize the rupee have included limiting currency speculation.

Can countries grow richer by exporting people, not goods?

The article explores whether exporting people, rather than goods, can lead to national prosperity, drawing on Kerala, India, as a case study where remittances from Gulf workers significantly boost living standards. While

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remittances clearly alleviate poverty and improve consumption, their effect on broader economic growth is less clear-cut, depending on whether "brain circulation" (like in India's IT sector) or limited spillover effects dominate. In Kerala, despite high literacy, anti-capitalist policies deter investment, leading bright graduates to seek opportunities abroad and limiting local productivity gains. The success of emigration-led growth is precarious, as it relies on external factors and foreign countries' willingness to accept migrants, a vulnerability highlighted by the recent plateauing of Keralites in the Gulf and potential decline in remittances due to the Iran war.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Genome editing can be risky. Meet the epigenome editors

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Epigenetic editing is emerging as a promising alternative to traditional gene editing, offering more precise control over gene activity without cutting the DNA molecule, thus reducing risks. This technology modifies "epigenomic tags"—chemical markers on DNA or histone proteins—to modulate gene expression, rather than simply turning genes on or off. Firms like Scribe Therapeutics, Tune Therapeutics, nChroma Bio, and Epicrispr Biotechnologies are developing epigenetic editors for conditions such as atherosclerosis, hepatitis B, and facioscapulohumeral muscular dystrophy (FSHD). Proponents highlight epigenetic editing's lower risk of off-target effects and potential for treating chronic diseases and even extending human lifespan, positioning it as a significant part of mid-21st century medicine.

A treatment for pre-eclampsia may be on the horizon

A promising novel treatment for pre-eclampsia, a dangerous pregnancy condition causing sudden blood

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pressure spikes and organ failure, has shown positive early results in trials. Researchers from Cedars-Sinai Medical Centre demonstrated that filtering the blood of pregnant women to remove soluble Fms-like tyrosine kinase 1 (sFlt-1), a troublesome protein, can safely slow the disease's progression. This treatment, which uses aphaeresis combined with an sFlt-1-binding antibody, extended pregnancies by a median of ten days in treated women without adverse effects for mothers or babies, a significant improvement over the four days offered by current standard care. While these are early proof-of-concept findings from a small study, experts believe it marks a crucial step toward a true disease-modifying treatment for pre-eclampsia.

A glimpse into cyber-security's AI-driven future

Black Hat Asia, a hacking conference, offers a look into the future of AI-driven cybersecurity, where sophisticated AI models are increasingly capable of

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identifying vulnerabilities and generating attacks. The Network Operations Centre (NOC) at Black Hat, which defends its network from thousands of expert hackers, has been using AI for years to combat both human and bot attacks, which have become faster and more skilled. The NOC has developed AI tools like a chatbot for database queries, a machine-learning system for detecting malware, and an AI agent to profile devices and flag unusual behavior, successfully identifying compromised devices and tracing malicious activity. Despite the immediate challenges of a turbulent transitional period with more flaws and breaches expected, experts believe AI will ultimately help cybersecurity, with new models rapidly surpassing current capabilities.

Is exercise as effective as treatments for depression and anxiety?

Two recent large meta-analyses suggest that exercise is as effective as conventional treatments like therapy or

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antidepressants in reducing symptoms of depression and anxiety. A Cochrane review of 69 trials and a meta-meta-analysis of over 1,000 trials concluded that exercise significantly improves mood. While acknowledging caveats such as potential bias in exercise trials and unfair comparisons with blinded antidepressant studies, researchers are confident in exercise's benefits. Aerobic workouts, especially group-based or supervised ones, are particularly effective for depression over several months, while lower-intensity activity helps with anxiety. The mechanisms are complex, possibly involving endocannabinoids, reduced inflammation, improved brain plasticity, increased dopamine transmission, and psychological benefits like a sense of achievement.

CULTURE

Is a fortune gathering dust in your attic?

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Demand for collectibles, driven by an ancient and ingrained human impulse, is booming, with auction houses increasingly entering a market traditionally dominated by specialist dealers. Heritage Auctions, a major player, reported record sales of \$2.16bn last year across diverse categories including coins, comics, sports cards, and entertainment memorabilia. The collectibles market is defined by "items made in multiples" and is "community validated," meaning value is determined by what individuals are willing to pay, often driven by passion and nostalgia. The success of companies like Heritage is attributed to early adoption of online sales, which provided transparent pricing information and allowed for aggressive expansion by subsuming smaller, expert-led operations.

The staggering strangeness of the Labubu bubble

The article describes a bizarre speculative bubble around "Labubu" dolls, grotesque elf-like figures that have sold

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for exorbitant sums, with one four-foot-tall version fetching \$150,000 at auction. This "Labubumania" represents a financial anomaly where prices have soared without traditional fundamental justification. While demand has recently cooled, with Google searches and manufacturer Pop Mart's share price falling, counterfeit "Lafufu" dolls emerged as a form of swindle during the peak. The bubble was ultimately "murdered" by Pop Mart itself, which massively expanded production, collapsing the secondary market for all but the rarest items. Though the bursting of this niche bubble is unlikely to have broader economic impacts, it offers a strange case study in speculative manias.

LA's levitating amoeba: a radically new kind of museum

The new David Geffen Galleries, home to the Los Angeles County Museum of Art (LACMA), is a radically designed structure that eschews traditional museum organization by geography, chronology, and

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medium. Its single floor is loosely arranged around themes like oceans and seas to emphasize trade and cultural exchange, aiming to inspire visitors to "wander" rather than follow a prescribed narrative. This approach aligns with a broader movement among Western institutions, like MoMA and Tate Modern, towards less hierarchical, more global galleries that reflect interconnected cultures. While such eclectic curation can spark serendipity, it risks confusing visitors who expect traditional contexts, although curators believe museums should be dynamic and responsive to their surroundings.

Celebrating one of literature's greatest pessimists

Austin, Texas, has celebrated Eeyore's birthday since 1964, a tradition started by literature students and now run by volunteers, to honor the gloomy yet kind donkey from A.A. Milne's Winnie-the-Pooh stories. This annual, free event, featuring costumes, live music, and a petting donkey, reminds people of Austin's enduring hippie

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spirit despite its growth into a tech hub. More significantly, it celebrates Eeyore, a character appreciated for his realism and his representation of the difficult but loyal friend. The party serves as a communal reminder that everyone sometimes needs cheering up, acknowledging Eeyore's depressive, anhedonic, and pessimistic yet dogged nature.

What really happened during the Black Death

Thomas Asbridge's "The Black Death: A Global History" offers a detailed account of the medieval plague, drawing parallels with covid-19 in its emergence, rapid spread, and societal disruption, but highlighting its far deadlier nature. The book emphasizes that the plague profoundly affected the Islamic world as much as Christian Europe, with Cairo suffering immensely. Asbridge argues that medieval people, despite their seemingly ignorant theories, responded with bravery and broadly sensible decisions, contrasting with modern

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contentious reactions to less lethal pandemics. The plague led to significant societal changes, including a boom in religious art, easier citizenship, and altered funerary customs, revealing how communities adapted and sometimes even thrived amidst unprecedented devastation.

In "The Devil Wears Prada 2", fashion magazines are off-trend

"The Devil Wears Prada 2" shifts its focus from fashion's cultural impact to the changing world of journalism, reflecting the struggles of print media in the social-media age. The sequel follows Andy Sachs, now an investigative journalist, as she returns to a scandal-ridden Runway magazine facing budget cuts and mass layoffs. The plot centers on Andy's race to find a billionaire buyer to save the magazine, which characters repeatedly acknowledge as increasingly irrelevant. Unlike the first film's insightful exploration of fashion's influence, the sequel struggles to articulate why Runway still matters,

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with Miranda Priestly offering a "toothless speech" about beauty and human endeavor.

ECONOMIC & FINANCIAL INDICATORS

Economic data, commodities and markets

No significant coverage this issue.

OBITUARY

Margareta Magnusson believed in leaving the world tidy

Margareta Magnusson, the Swedish guru of "döstädning" or death-cleaning, died believing in the moral and environmental duty to declutter before passing away, leaving minimal possessions. Her habit of tidying

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extended from public spaces to her own home, where she meticulously organized, donated, and shredded items, keeping only essentials or things full of meaning. Magnusson, an artist, had ample experience with moving and clearing out homes after family deaths, which informed her bestselling book, "The Gentle Art of Swedish Death-Cleaning." She advocated for living more lightly in the present and saw death-cleaning not about death itself, but about embracing curiosity and joy in old age.